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“The City of Theory”

from *Cities of Tomorrow: An Intellectual History of Urban Planning and Design in the Twentieth Century*, 3rd edn (2001)

Peter Hall

EDITORS' INTRODUCTION



This selection from British geographer/planner/polymath Sir Peter Hall's magisterial intellectual history of urban planning and design in the twentieth century, *Cities of Tomorrow*, discusses the evolution of planning theory in the United States and the UK – the body of abstract philosophical writings that guide day-to-day urban planning practice. Hall's focus is on planning theory in the West, but his analysis has been enormously influential everywhere in the world. In another selection in this part of *The City Reader* Bishwapriya Sanyal (p. 525) describes ways in which the paradigms Hall discusses have played out in the developing world. While the Western paradigms have been influential worldwide, planning theory is shaped by to local planning cultures based on the history and level of development in the country and the unique social, economic, and cultural forces at play. This leads to what Sanyal calls “hybrids.” He concludes that there is little probability that a one-size-fits-all global planning theory will develop and that is as it should be.

Over time, the way in which people think about a subject changes. Sometimes the change is gradual with modest additions and refinements to what is generally understood. But from time to time there are sharp breaks in the continuity of theory. The ideas of paradigms and revolutionary changes in scientific thinking were best articulated by physicist and historian of science Thomas Kuhn in an influential book titled *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1962). Kuhn distinguished “scientific revolutions,” in which revolutionary breakthroughs in thinking occur, from “normal science” in which knowledge advances slowly and incrementally. Sixteenth-century Italian astronomer Nicolaus Copernicus's theory placing the sun at the center of our solar system with planets (including earth) revolving around it, rather than a stationary flat earth at the center of the universe, for example, qualifies as a revolutionary scientific breakthrough, while mapping craters on Mars would be normal science. The crater mapping is an addition to human knowledge consistent with established theory, but Copernicus's theory represents a whole new way of looking at the universe. Urban planning is a form of normative practice based on social science. A theory that urban planning should be done using computer models rather than architectural drawings would be a paradigm shift, but John Forester's illuminating discussion of how urban planners resolve conflicts (p. 467) is an example of a “normal science” extension of social science knowledge about how to do urban planning.

Hall uses the term “paradigm” and describes major changes in planning theory as “paradigm shifts.” He describes a succession of planning theory paradigms that have evolved during the past hundred years.

According to Hall, the first planning paradigm of the modern era viewed urban planning as essentially architecture writ large. Hall points out that before World War II, urban planning was defined as the craft of physical planning. Professors who had been educated as architects dominated urban planning teaching and writing. The first generation of planning professors taught students to prepare architectural drawings extended to city scale – particularly self-contained, end-state physical plans like Raymond Unwin's plan for the Garden City

of Letchworth, England. Planners were viewed as a privileged elite and were not expected to interact with the people for whom they were planning. Once a well-crafted, aesthetically pleasing, functional plan was complete on paper, the first generation of planning theorists believed that a city could be built just as a house is built from architectural drawings. The first generation of urban planners in India adopted this approach, and urban planning in India and elsewhere in the British colonies was based on the planning as design paradigm. That was true in other developing countries, too. A small number of architects and engineers in China, Indonesia, South and Central America, and Africa taught urban planning courses, concerned almost exclusively with urban design. Planning practitioners were almost all architects or engineers.

As Hall notes, few planners actually get to plan whole new towns from scratch. Rather, they usually have to decide how to integrate new housing, streets, commercial and retail districts, industrial areas, parks, open space, and infrastructure into existing cities and emerging suburbs. City planning does not end the way an architect's plan for a new house does with a final set of drawings that will be built exactly as drawn. Rather, city planning is an ongoing, fluid, messy process. Nor is the urban planning process a value-neutral, scientific process in which an educated elite can pick the best solution to a planning problem and have the client meekly endorse it. As Paul Davidoff describes (p. 481) urban planning is a political process that requires planners to choose among conflicting values. John Forester (p. 467) describes these conflicts and how urban planners navigate them. Tidy ivory-tower plans have little chance of being implemented. Effective urban planning requires planners to interact with citizens – ideally along the higher rungs of Sherry Arnstein's ladder of citizen participation (p. 279). In developing countries planning is as political or more so than in the West.

During the 1960s, systems analysts who had been educated as computer scientists, quantitative geographers, engineers, and regional economists developed a competing paradigm of what urban planning should be. They argued that urban planning should be a science, not a craft. They felt planners could and should base their plans on analysis of empirical data and use quantitative methodologies to plan transportation and other urban systems on an ongoing basis. The early urban planners who viewed urban planning as a branch of systems analysis were pioneers in using computers at a time when computers were new, costly, and hard to use. The systems theorists thought plans should be mathematical models rather than end-state architectural drawings. A first generation planner educated at the University of Liverpool in the 1920s who could produce a series of large, carefully drafted blueprints and design sketches for a new town would not know what to make of a systems planner educated at the University of Manchester or the Massachusetts Institute of Technology in the 1960s, presenting a series of equations and mathematical computer models showing how land should be subdivided, roads built, and parks dedicated over time as “the plan” for the same new town.

Planners have to confront questions of what kind of city they are planning and for whom. People hold strong and conflicting values of what makes a good city. Ebenezer Howard's vision of compact, human-scale Garden Cities (p. 371) is very different from Le Corbusier's vision of a radiant city for three million inhabitants consisting of massive high-rise buildings surrounded by parks and gardens (p. 379) or Frank Lloyd Wright's Broadacre City vision (p. 388), where every household would live in a single-family home with a minimum of an acre of land per person. Plans that introduce green, sustainable, carbon neutral, resilient, equity, non-sexist, transit-oriented values may graft any of these “branches” onto the “sturdy trunk” of the conventional urban general plan tree that Edward J. Kaiser and David R. Godschalk (p. 445) describe as central to most urban planning today.

In the 1960s and 1970s many planners shaken by urban racial and class conflict concluded that urban planning was too important to leave to either elitist designers following the craft approach to planning or technocratic planners following the systems-planning model. Liberal planners and academics of the 1960s and 1970s such as Paul Davidoff and Sherry Arnstein focused on planning outcomes and whom the city was being built for. While most cities were run by what Harvey Molotch calls “growth machines” that considered business interests most important, Davidoff, Arnstein, and other liberals saw urban planning as a vehicle that could benefit poor and powerless people rather than serve the interests of established business elites, pro-growth local governments and self-serving suburbanites intent on excluding low-income and minority households. David Harvey (p. 270) and other neo-Marxist planners went much further.

Twentieth-century neo-Marxists could not directly apply the categories Friedrich Engels and Karl Marx used to describe the class structure of mid-nineteenth-century Manchester, England (p. 53) to post-industrial cities

where service work has replaced much factory labor. In communist and socialist countries, the Marxist paradigm – particularly based on the model of the Soviet Union as Tingwei Zhang describes in the case of China (p. 687) – is the basis for planning. Marxist planners focus on centralized national economic development planning to build heavy industry and collectivizing agriculture – not battles over the consumption of finished goods or anti-imperialist concerns that dominated neo-Marxist planners' debates in the West. In the West, the stark class conflict between an oppressed industrial proletariat and wealthy owners of the means of production that characterized mid-nineteenth-century industrial cities had become far more complicated by the 1960s. Inequality, exclusion, racial segregation, and lack of opportunity were manifest in cities, but the categories had become more complex. Urban planning generally favored affluent, well-connected, white, male, straight, business-oriented residents rather than poor and working-class residents, racial and ethnic minorities, immigrants, women, and gays. Accordingly neo-Marxist theorists updated class analysis based on Karl Marx's theory. Neo-Marxist urban theory was an important part of academic urban planning discourse throughout the 1970s.

Hall ends his tour of planning theory with some critical comments on the current divorce between planning theory and practice. He argues that as graduate programs in city and regional planning have grown in number and size, and as a formal body of planning theory has developed, too often academic planners today merely debate each other's academic theories with little attention to actual planning practice or the needs of planning practitioners on the front lines. As a result, practitioners consider much of the planning theory academics develop sterile and irrelevant. Finding academic planning theory irrelevant, urban planning practitioners concern themselves only with the nuts-and-bolts of planning practice without the deeper understanding relevant theory could offer. Hall calls for an improved, reciprocal relationship between the two: theory that is informed by and relevant to planning practice and planning practice informed and improved by (more relevant) theory. John Forester's empirical research and practical theorizing (p. 467) is a good example of how Hall feels academic planning theorists might wed theory and practice. Forester interviewed dozens of practicing planners so that he was very knowledgeable about actual planning practice and then developed theory based on what they told him. This theory in turn has helped inform and improve planning practice as practitioners put into practice the theoretical insights that Forester developed.

The selection in this part of *The City Reader* entitled "Hybrid Planning Cultures: The Search for the Global Cultural Commons" by Bishwapriya Sanyal picks up Hall's arguments and describes their relevance in different countries.

Peter Hall (1932–2014) taught urban planning at the Bartlett School of Architecture and Planning, University College, London from 1994 until his death. Between 1968 and 1989 he taught in and chaired both the geography and planning departments of the University of Reading in the UK. Beginning in 1980 he began shuttling between Reading and the University of California, Berkeley, where he also taught in both the geography and urban planning departments and directed Berkeley's Institute of Urban and Regional Development. Hall left Reading in 1989 and Berkeley in 1992 to become the Bartlett Professor of planning at the Bartlett School, University College London. In addition to his knighthood, Hall's numerous honors include the founder's medal of the Royal Geographical Society, membership of the British Academy, and the prestigious Balzan Prize in 2005 for *Cities in Civilization*.

Hall's writings about planning theory are informed by the experience of actual planning. In addition to his academic accomplishments, Hall worked on planning projects as varied as the English Channel tunnel link, bringing high-speed bullet trains to California, and revitalizing the depressed seaside town of Blackpool, England, where he grew up. He has served as an advisor to successive UK governments including serving as Special Adviser on Strategic Planning to the British government from 1991 to 1994 and as a member of the Office of the Deputy Prime Minister's Urban Task Force from 1998 to 1999.

This selection is from *Cities of Tomorrow: An Intellectual History of Urban Planning and Design in the Twentieth Century*, 3rd edn (Oxford: Blackwell, 2001). Other of Peter Hall's books include *Good Cities, Better Lives: How Europe Discovered the Lost Art of Urbanism* (London and New York: Routledge, 2013), *Urban and Regional Planning*, 5th edn, co-authored with Mark Tewdwr-Jones (London and New York: Routledge, 2010), *Cities in Civilization* (New York: Pantheon, 1998), *The World Cities*, 3rd edn (London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson; New York: St. Martin's, 1984), and *Great Planning Disasters* (Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 1982).

Section 2 of Eugenie Birch's *Urban and Regional Planning Reader* (London and New York: Routledge, 2006) contains additional planning theory selections. Other overviews of planning theory include Susan Fainstein and Scott Campbell, *Readings in Urban Theory*, 3rd edn (London: Blackwell, 2011), Michael Brooks, *Planning Theory for Practitioners* (Chicago: APA Press, 2002), Philip Allmendinger, *Planning Theory* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2002), Nigel Taylor, *Urban Planning Theory since 1945* (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage, 1998), Seymour Mandelbaum (ed.), *Explorations in Planning Theory* (Rutgers: Center for Urban Policy Research Press, 1996), and John Friedmann, *Planning in the Public Domain: From Knowledge to Action* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1987).

Richard LeGates and Frederic Stout (eds.) *Early Urban Planning 1870–1940* (London: Routledge/Thoemmes, 1998) is an eight-volume set containing the full texts of classic early urban planning theory books by Ebenezer Howard, Patrick Geddes, Patrick Abercrombie, Clarence Perry, Nelson P. Lewis, John Nolen, and Charles Mulford Robinson, and articles by Daniel Burnham, Frederick Law Olmsted, Edwin Chadwick, Arturo Soria y Mata, Walter D. Moody, Raymond Unwin, Lawrence Veiller, Frederic C. Howe, A.D. Sanderson Furniss and Marion Phillips, Catherine Bauer, Edward Bassett, and Rexford Tugwell.

PLANNING AND THE ACADEMY: PHILADELPHIA, MANCHESTER, CALIFORNIA, PARIS, 1955–1987

... about 1955 ... city planning at last became legitimate; but in doing so, it began to sow the seeds of its own destruction. All too quickly, it split into two separate camps: the one, in the schools of planning, increasingly and exclusively obsessed with the theory of the subject; the other, in the offices of local authorities and consultants, concerned only with the everyday business of planning in the real world. That division was not at first evident; indeed, during the late 1950s and most of the 1960s, it seemed that at last a complete and satisfactory link had been forged between the world of theory and the world of practice. But all too soon, illusion was stripped aside: honeymoon was followed in quick succession during the 1970s by tiffs and temporary reconciliations, in the 1980s by divorce. And, in the process, planning lost much of its new-found legitimacy.

The prehistory of academic city planning 1930–1955

It was not that planning was innocent of academic influence before the 1950s. On the contrary: in virtually every urbanized nation, universities and polytechnics had created courses for the professional education of planners; professional bodies had come into existence to define and protect standards, and had forged links with the academic departments. Britain

took an early lead when in 1909 ... the soap magnate William Hesketh Lever, founder of Port Sunlight, won a libel action against a newspaper and used the proceeds to endow his local University of Liverpool with a Department of Civic Design. Stanley Adshead, the first professor, almost immediately created a new journal, the *Town Planning Review*, in which theory and good practice were to be firmly joined; its first editor was a young faculty recruit, Patrick Abercrombie, who was later to succeed Adshead in the chair first at Liverpool, then at Britain's second school of planning: University College London, founded in 1914. The Town Planning Institute – the Royal accolade was conferred only in 1959 – was founded in 1914 on the joint initiative of the Royal Institute of British Architects, the Institution of Civil Engineers and the Royal Institution of Chartered Surveyors; by the end of the 1930s, it had recognized seven schools whose examinations provided an entry to membership.

The United States was slower: though Harvard had established a planning course in 1909, neck and neck with Liverpool, it had no separate department until 1929. Nevertheless, by the 1930s America had schools also at MIT, Cornell, Columbia and Illinois, as well as courses taught in other departments at a great many universities across the country. And the American City Planning Institute, founded in 1917 as a breakaway from the National Conference on City Planning, ten years later became – mainly through the insistence of Thomas Adams – a full-fledged professional body on TPI lines, a status it retained when in 1938 it broadened to include regional planning and renamed itself the American Institute of Planners.

The important point about these, and other, initiatives was this: stemming as they did from professional needs, often through spin-offs from related professions like architecture and engineering, they were from the start heavily suffused with the professional styles of these design-based professions.

The job of the planners was to make plans, to develop codes to enforce these plans, and then to enforce those codes; relevant planning knowledge was what was needed for that job; planning education existed to convey that knowledge together with the necessary design skills. So, by 1950, the utopian age of planning ... was over; planning was now institutionalized into comprehensive land-use planning. All this was strongly reflected in the curricula of the planning schools down to the mid-1950s, and often for years after that; and these in turn were reflected in the books and articles that academic planners wrote. Land-use planning, Keeble told his British audience in 1959 and Kent reminded the American counterpart in 1964, was a distinct and tightly bounded subject, quite different from social or economic planning. And these texts reflected the fact that "city planners early adopted the thoughtways and the analytical methods that engineers developed for the design of public works, and they then applied them to the design of cities."

The result, as Michael Batty has put it, was a subject that for the ordinary citizen was "somewhat mystical" or arcane, as law or medicine were, but that was – in sharp contrast to education for these older professions – not based on any consistent body of theory; rather, in it, "scatterings of social science bolstered the traditional architectural determinism." Planners acquired a synthetic ability not through abstract thinking, but by doing real jobs; in them, they used first creative intuition, then reflection. Though they might draw on bits and pieces of theory about the city – the Chicago school's sociological differentiation of the city, the land economists' theory of urban land rent differentials, the geographers' concepts of the natural region – these were employed simply as snippets of useful knowledge. In the important distinction later made by a number of writers, there was some theory in planning but there was no theory of planning. The whole process was very direct, based on a single-shot approach: survey (the Geddesian approach) was followed by analysis (an implicit learning approach), followed immediately by design.

True, as Abercrombie's classic text of 1933 argued, the making of the plan was only half the planner's job;

the other half consisted of planning, that is implementation, but it was nowhere assumed that some kind of continuous learning process was needed. True, too, the 1947 Act provided for plans – and the surveys on which they were based – to be quinquennially updated; the assumption was still that the result would be a fixed land-use plan. And, a decade after that, though Keeble's equally classic text referred to the planning process, by this he simply meant the need for a spatial hierarchy of related plans from the regional to the local, and the need at each scale for survey before plan. Nowhere is found a discussion of implementation or updating. Thus – apart from extremely generalized statements like Abercrombie's famous triad of 'beauty, health and convenience' – the goals were left implicit; the planner would develop them intuitively from his own values, which by definition were "expert" and apolitical.

So, in the classic British land-use planning system created by the 1947 Town and Country Planning Act, no repeated learning process was involved, since the planner would get it right first time:

The process was therefore not characterized by explicit feedback as the search "homed in" on the best plan, for the notion that the planner had to learn about the nature of the problem was in direct conflict with his assumed infallibility as an expert, a professional ... The assumed certainty of the process was such that possible links back to the reality in the form of new surveys were rarely if ever considered ... This certainty, based on the infallibility of the expert, reinforced the apolitical, technical nature of the process. The political environment was regarded as totally passive, indeed subservient to the "advice" of the planners and in practice, this was largely the case.

(Batty, 1979)

It was, as Batty calls it, the golden age of planning: the planner, free from political interference, serenely sure of his technical capacities, was left to get on with the job. And this was appropriate to the world outside, with which planning had to deal: a world of glacially slow change – stagnant population, depressed economy – in which major planning interventions would come only seldom and for a short time, as after a major war. Abercrombie, in the plan for the West Midlands he produced with Herbert Jackson in 1948, actually wrote that a major objective of the plan should be to slow down the rate of urban

change, thus reducing the rate at which built structures became obsolescent: the ideal city would be a static, stable city:

Let us assume . . . that a maximum population has been decided for a town, arrived at after consideration of all the factors appearing to be relevant . . . Allowance has been made for proper space for all conceivable purposes in the light of present facts and the town planner's experience and imagination. Accordingly, an envelope or green belt has been prescribed, outside which the land uses will be those involving little in the way of resident population. The town planner is now in the happy position for the first time of knowing the limits of his problem. He is able to address himself to the design of the whole and the parts in the light of a basic overall figure for population. The process will be difficult enough in itself, but at least he starts with one figure to reassure him.

(Abercrombie and Jackson, 1948)

American planning was never quite like that. Kent's text of 1964 on the urban general plan, though it deals with the same kind of land-use planning, reminds its students of end-directions which are continually adjusted as time passes. And, because the planner's basic understanding of the interrelationship between socio-economic forces and the physical environment was largely intuitive and speculative, Kent warned his student readers,

In most cases it is not possible to know with any certainty what physical design measures should be taken to bring about a given social or economic objective, or what social and economic consequences will result from a given physical-design proposal. Therefore, the city council and the city-planning commission, rather than professional city planners, should make the final value judgements upon which the plan is based.

(Kent, 1964)

But even Kent was certain that, despite all this, it was still possible for the planner to produce some kind of optimal land use plan; the problem of objectives was just shunted off.

The systems revolution

It was a happy, almost dream-like, world. But increasingly, during the 1950s, it did not correspond to reality.

Everything began to get out of hand. In every industrial country, there was an unexpected baby boom, to which the demographers reacted with surprise, the planners with alarm; only its timing varied from one country to another, and everywhere it created instant demands for maternity wards and child-care clinics, only slightly delayed needs for schools and playgrounds. In every one, almost simultaneously, the great postwar economic boom got under way, bringing pressures for new investment in factories and offices. And, as boom generated affluence, these countries soon passed into the realms of high mass-consumption societies, with unprecedented demands for durable consumer goods: most notable among these, land-hungry homes and cars. The result everywhere – in America, in Britain, in the whole of western Europe – was that the pace of urban development and urban change began to accelerate to an almost superheated level. The old planning system, geared to a static world, was overwhelmed.

These demands in themselves would force the system to change; but, almost coincidentally, there were changes on the supply side too. In the mid-1950s there occurred an intellectual revolution in the whole cluster of urban and regional social studies, which provided planners with much of their borrowed intellectual baggage. A few geographers and industrial economists discovered the works of German theorists of location, such as Johann Heinrich von Thünen (1826) on agriculture, Alfred Weber (1909) on industry, Walter Christaller (1933) on central places, and August Lösch (1940) on the general theory of location; they began to summarize and analyse these works, and where necessary to translate them. In the United States, academics coming from a variety of disciplines began to find regularities in many distributions, including spatial ones. Geographers, beginning to espouse the tenets of logical positivism, suggested that their subject should cease to be concerned with descriptions of the detailed differentiation of the earth's surface, and should instead begin to develop general hypotheses about spatial distributions, which could then be rigorously tested against reality: the very approach which these German pioneers of location theory had adopted. These ideas, together with the relevant literature, were brilliantly synthesized by an American economist, Walter Isard, in a text that became immediately influential. Between 1953 and 1957, there occurred an almost instant revolution in human geography and the creation, by Isard, of a new academic

discipline uniting the new geography with the German tradition of locational economics. And, with official blessing – as in the important report of Britain's Schuster Committee of 1950, which recommended a greater social science content in planning education – the new locational analysis began to enter the curricula of the planning schools.

The consequences for planning were momentous: with only a short timelag, "the discipline of physical planning changed more in the 10 years from 1960 to 1970, than in the previous 100, possibly even 1000 years" (Batty, 1979).

The subject changed from a kind of craft, based on personal knowledge of a rudimentary collection of concepts about the city, into an apparently scientific activity in which vast amounts of precise information were garnered and processed in such a way that the planner could devise very sensitive systems of guidance and control, the effects of which could be monitored and if necessary modified. More precisely, cities and regions were viewed as complex systems – they were, indeed, only a particular spatially based subset of a whole general class of systems – while planning was seen as a continuous process of control and monitoring of these systems, derived from the then new science of cybernetics developed by Norbert Wiener.

There was thus, in the language later used in the celebrated work of Thomas Kuhn, a "paradigm shift." It affected city planning as it affected many other related areas of planning and design. Particularly, its main early applications – already in the mid-1950s – concerned defence and aerospace; for these were the Cold War years, when the United States was engaging in a crash programme to build new and complex electronically controlled missile systems. Soon, from that field, spun off another application. Already in 1954, Robert Mitchell and Chester Rapkin – colleagues of Isard at the University of Pennsylvania – had published a book suggesting that urban traffic patterns were a direct and measurable function of the pattern of activities – and thus land uses – that generated them. Coupled with earlier work on spatial interaction patterns, and using for the first time the data-processing powers of the computer, this produced a new science of urban transportation planning, which for the first time claimed to be able scientifically to predict future urban-traffic patterns. First applied in the historic Detroit Metropolitan Area transportation study of 1955, further developed in the Chicago study of 1956, it soon became a standardized methodology

employed in literally hundreds of such studies, first across the United States, then across the world.

Heavily engineering-based in its approach, it adopted a fairly standardized sequence. First, explicit goals and objectives were set for the performance of the system. Then, inventories were taken of the existing state of the system: both the traffic flows, and the activities that gave rise to them. From this, models were derived which sought to establish these relationships in precise mathematical form. Then, forecasts were made of the future state of the system, based on the relationships obtained from the models. From this, alternative solutions could be designed and evaluated in order to choose a preferred option. Finally, once implemented the network would be continually monitored and the system modified as necessary.

At first, these relationships were seen as operating in one direction: activities and land uses were given; from these, the traffic patterns were derived. So the resulting methodology and techniques were part of a new field, transportation planning, which came to exist on one side of traditional city planning. Soon, however, American regional scientists suggested a crucial modification: the locational patterns of activities – commercial, industrial, residential – were in turn influenced by the available transportation opportunities; these relationships, too, could be precisely modelled and used for prediction; therefore the relationship was two-way, and there was a need to develop an interactive system of land-use–transportation planning for entire metropolitan or subregional areas. Now, for the first time, the engineering-based approach invaded the professional territory of the traditional land-use planner. Spatial interaction models, especially the Garin–Lowry model – which, given basic data about employment and transportation links, could generate a resulting pattern of activities and land uses – became part of the planner's stock in trade. As put in one of the classic systems texts:

In this general process of planning we particularise in order to deal with more specific issues: that is, a specific real world system or subsystem must be represented by a specific conceptual system or subsystem within the general conceptual system. Such a particular representation of a system is called a *model* . . . the use of models is a means whereby the high variety of the real world is reduced to a level of variety appropriate to the channel capacities of the human being.

(Chadwick, 1971)

This involved more than a knowledge of computer applications – novel as that seemed to the average planner of the 1960s. It meant also a fundamentally different concept of planning. Instead of the old master-plan or blueprint approach, which assumed that the objectives were fixed from the start, the new concept was of planning as a process, “whereby programmes are adapted during their implementation as and when incoming information requires such changes”. And this planning process was independent of the thing that was planned; as Melvin Webber put it, it was “a special way of deciding and acting” which involved a constantly recycled series of logical steps: goal-setting, forecasting of change in the outside world, assessment of chains of consequences of alternative courses of action, appraisal of costs and benefits as a basis for action strategies, and continuous monitoring. This was the approach of the new British textbooks of systems planning, which started to emerge at the end of the 1960s, and which were particularly associated with a group of younger British graduates, many teaching or studying at the University of Manchester. It was also the approach of a whole generation of subregional studies, made for fast-growing metropolitan areas in Britain during that heroic period of growth and change, 1965–75: Leicester–Leicestershire, Nottinghamshire–Derbyshire, Coventry–Warwickshire–Solihull, South Hampshire. All were heavily suffused with the new approach and the new techniques; in several, the same key individuals – McLoughlin in Leicester, Batty in Notts–Derby – played a directing or a crucial consulting role.

But the revolution was less complete – at least, in its early stages – than its supporters liked to argue: many of these “systems” plans had a distinctly blueprint tint, in that they soon resulted in all-too-concrete proposals for fixed investments like freeway systems. Underlying this, furthermore, were some curious metaphysical assumptions, which the new systems planners shared with their blueprint elders: the planning system was seen as active, the city system as purely passive; the political system was regarded as benign and receptive to the planner’s expert advice. In practice, the systems planner was involved in two very different kinds of activity: as a social scientist, he or she was passively observing and analysing reality; as a designer, the same planner was acting on reality to change it – an activity inherently less certain, and also inherently subject to objectives that could only be set through a complex,

often messy, set of dealings between professionals, politicians and public.

The core of this problem was a logical paradox: despite the claims of the systems planners, the urban planning system was different from (say) a weapons system. In this latter kind of system, to which the “systems approach” had originally and successfully been applied, the controls were inside the system; but here, the urban-regional system was inside its own system of control. Related to this were other crucial differences: in urban planning, there was not just one problem and one overriding objective, but many, perhaps contradictory; it was difficult to move from general goals to specific operational ones; not all were fully perceived; the systems to be analysed did not self-evidently exist, but had to be synthesized; most aspects were not deterministic, but probabilistic; costs and benefits were difficult to quantify. So the claims of the systems school to scientific objectivity could not readily be fulfilled. Increasingly, members of the school came to admit that in such “open” systems, systematic analysis would need to play a subsidiary role to intuition and judgement; in other words, the traditional approach. By 1975 Britton Harris, perhaps the most celebrated of all the systems planners, could write that he no longer believed that the more difficult problems of planning could be solved by optimizing methods.

The search for a new paradigm

All this, in the late 1960s, came to focus in an attack from two very different directions, which together blew the ship of systems planning at least half out of the water. From the philosophical right came a series of theoretical and empirical studies from American political scientists, arguing that – at least in the United States – crucial urban decisions were made within a pluralist political structure in which no one individual or group had total knowledge or power, and in which, consequently, the decision-making process could best be described as “disjointed incrementalism” or “muddling through”. Meyerson and Banfield’s classic analysis of the Chicago Housing Authority concluded that it engaged in little real planning, and failed because it did not correctly identify the real power structure in the city; its elitist view of the public interest was totally opposed to the populist view of the ward politicians, which finally prevailed. Downs theorized

about such a structure, suggesting that politicians buy votes by offering bundles of policies, rather as in a market. Lindblom contrasted the whole rational-comprehensive model of planning with what he found to be the actual process of policy development, which was characterized by a mixture of values and analysis, a confusion of ends and means, a failure to analyse alternatives, and an avoidance of theory. Altshuler's analysis of Minneapolis–St Paul suggested that the professional planner carried no clout against the political machine, which backed the highway-building engineers against him; they won by stressing expertise and concentrating on narrow goals, but theirs was a political game; the conclusion was that planners should recognize their own weakness, and devise strategies appropriate to that fact.

All these analyses arose from study of American urban politics, which is traditionally more populist, more pluralist, than most. Even there, Rabinowitz's study of New Jersey cities suggested that they varied greatly in style, from the highly fragmented to the very cohesive; while Etzioni, criticizing Lindblom, suggested that recent United States history showed several important examples of non-incremental decision-making, especially in defence. But, these reservations taken, the studies did at least suggest that planning in actuality was a very long way indeed from the cool, rational, Olympian style envisaged in the systems texts. Perhaps it might have been better if it had been closer; perhaps not. The worrisome point was that in practice, local democracy proved to be an infinitely messier business than the theory would have liked. Some theorists accordingly concluded that if this was the way planning was, this was the way it should be encouraged to be: partial, experimental, incremental, working on problems as they arose.

That emerged even more clearly, because – as so often seems to happen – in America the left-wing criticism was reaching closely similar conclusions. By the late 1960s, fuelled by the civil-rights movement and war on poverty, the protests against the Vietnam war and the campus free-speech movement, it was this wing that was making all the running. Underlying the general current of protest were three key themes, which proved fatal to the legitimacy of the systems planners. One was a widespread distrust of expert, top-down planning generally – whether for problems of peace and war, or for problems of the cities. Another, much more specific, was an increasing paranoia about the systems approach, which in its military

applications was seen as employing pseudo-science and incomprehensible jargon to create a smokescreen, behind which ethically reprehensible policies could be pursued. And a third was triggered by the riots that tore through American cities starting with Birmingham, Alabama, in 1963 and ending with Detroit, in 1967. They seemed to prove the point: systems planning had done nothing to ameliorate the condition of the cities; rather, by assisting or at least conniving in the dismemberment of inner-city communities, it might actually have contributed to it. By 1967 one critic, Richard Bolan, could argue that systems planning was old-fashioned comprehensive planning, dressed up in fancier garb; both, alike, ignored political reality.

The immediate left-wing reaction was to call on the planners themselves to turn the tables, and to practise bottom-up planning by becoming advocate-planners. Particularly, in this way they would make explicit the debate about the setting of goals and objectives, which both the blueprint and systems approaches had bypassed by means of their comfortable shared assumption that this was the professional planner's job. Advocacy planners would intervene in a variety of ways, in a variety of groups; diversity should be their keynote. They would help to inform the public of alternatives; force public planning agencies to compete for support; help critics to generate plans that were superior to official ones; compel consideration of underlying values. The resulting structure was highly American: democratic, locally grounded, pluralistic, but also legalistic in being based on institutionalized conflict. But, interestingly, while demoting the planner in one respect, it enormously advanced his or her power in another: the planner was to take many of the functions that the locally elected official had previously exercised. And, in practice, it was not entirely clear how it would all work; particularly, how the process would resolve the very real conflicts of interest that could arise within communities, or how it could avoid the risk that the planners, once again, would become manipulators.

At any rate, there is more than a passing resemblance between the planner as a disjointed incrementalist, and the planner-advocate; and, indeed, between either of these and a third model set out in Bolan's paper of 1967, the planner as informal co-ordinator and catalyst, which in turn shades into a fourth: Melvin Webber's probabilistic planner, who uses new information systems to facilitate debate and improve decision-making. All are assumed to work

within a pluralist world, with very many different competing groups and interests, where the planner has at most (and, further, should have) only limited power or influence; all are based, at least implicitly, on continued acceptance of logical positivism. As Webber put it, at the conclusion of his long two-part paper of 1968–9:

The burden of my argument is that city planning failed to adopt the planning method, choosing instead to impose input bundles, including regulatory constraints, on the basis of ideologically defined images of goodness. I am urging, as an alternative, that planning tries out the planning idea and the planning method.

In turn, Webber's view of planning – which flatly denied the possibility of a stable predictable future or agreed goals – provided some of the philosophical underpinnings of the Social Learning or New Humanist approach of the 1970s, which stressed the importance of learning systems in helping cope with a turbulent environment. But finally, this approach divorced itself from logical positivism, returning to a reliance on personal knowledge which was strangely akin to old-style blueprint planning; and, as developed by John Friedmann of the University of California at Los Angeles, it finally resulted in a demand for all political activity to be decomposed into decision by minute political groups: a return to the anarchist roots of planning, with a vengeance.

So these different approaches diverged, sometimes in detailed emphasis, sometimes more fundamentally. What they shared was the belief that – at any rate in the American political system – the planner did not have much power and did not deserve to have much either; within a decade, from 1965 to 1975, these approaches together neatly stripped the planner of whatever priestly clothing, and consequent mystique, s/he may have possessed. Needless to say, this view powerfully communicated itself to the professionals themselves. Even in countries with more centralized, top-down political systems, such as Great Britain, young graduating planners increasingly saw their roles as rather like barefoot doctors, helping the poor down on the streets of the inner city, working either for a politically acceptable local authority, or, failing that, for community organizations battling against a politically objectionable one.

Several historical factors, in addition to the demolition job on planning by the American theorists, contributed to this change: planners and politicians

belatedly discovered the continued deprivation of the inner-city poor; then, it was seen that the areas where these people lived were suffering depopulation and deindustrialization; in consequence, planners progressively moved away from the merely physical, and into the social and the economic. The change can be caricatured thus: in 1955, the typical newly graduated planner was at the drawing board, producing a diagram of desired land uses; in 1965, s/he was analysing computer output of traffic patterns; in 1975, the same person was talking late into the night with community groups, in the attempt to organize against hostile forces in the world outside.

It was a remarkable inversion of roles. For what was wholly or partly lost, in that decade, was the claim to any unique and useful expertise, such as was possessed by the doctor or the lawyer. True, the planner could still offer specialized knowledge on planning laws and procedures, or on how to achieve a particular design solution; though often, given the nature of the context and the changed character of planning education, s/he might not have enough of either of these skills to be particularly useful. And, some critics were beginning to argue, this was because planning had extended so thinly over so wide an area that it became almost meaningless; in the title of Aaron Wildavsky's celebrated paper, "If Planning is Everything, Maybe it's Nothing".

The fact was that planning, as an academic discipline, had theorized about its own role to such an extent that it was denying its own claim to legitimacy. Planning, Faludi pointed out in his text of 1973, could be merely *functional*, in that the goals and objectives are taken as given; or *normative*, in that they are themselves the object of rational choice. The problem was whether planning was really capable of doing that latter job. As a result, by the mid-1970s planning had reached the stage of a "paradigm crisis"; it had been theoretically useful to distinguish the planning process as something separate from what is planned, yet this had meant a neglect of substantive theory, pushing it to the periphery of the whole subject. Consequently, new theory is needed which attempts to bridge current planning strategies and the urban physical and social systems to which strategies are applied.

The Marxist ascendancy

That became ever clearer in the following decade, when the logical positivists retreated from the

intellectual field of battle and the Marxists took possession. As the whole world knows, the 1970s saw a remarkable resurgence – indeed a veritable explosion – of Marxist studies. This could not fail to affect the closely related worlds of urban geography, sociology, economics and planning. True, like the early neo-classical economists, Marx had been remarkably uninterested in questions of spatial location – even though Engels had made illuminating comments on the spatial distribution of classes in mid-Victorian Manchester. The disciples now reverently sought to extract from the holy texts, drop by drop, a distillation that could be used to brew the missing theoretical potion. At last, by the mid-1970s, it was ready; then came a flood of new work. It originated in various places and in various disciplines: in England and the United States the geographers David Harvey and Doreen Massey helped to explain urban growth and change in terms of the circulation of capital; in Paris, Manuel Castells and Henri Lefebvre developed sociologically based theories. In the endless debates that followed among the Marxists themselves, a critical question concerned the role of the state. In France, Lokjine and others argued that it was mainly concerned, through such devices as macroeconomic planning and related infrastructure investment, directly to underpin and aid the direct productive investments of private capital. Castells, in contrast, argued that its main function had been to provide collective consumption – as in public housing, or schools, or transportation – to help guarantee the reproduction of the labour force and to dampen class conflict, essential for the maintenance of the system. Clearly, planning might play a very large role in both these state functions; hence, by the mid-1970s French Marxist urbanists were engaging in major studies of this role in the industrialization of such major industrial areas as Dieppe.

At the same time, a specifically Marxian view of planning emerged in the English-speaking world. To describe it adequately would require a course in Marxist theory. But, in inadequate summary, it states that the structure of the capitalist city itself, including its land-use and activity patterns, is the result of capital in pursuit of profit. Because capitalism is doomed to recurrent crises, which deepen in the current stage of late capitalism, capital calls upon the state, as its agent, to assist it by remedying disorganization in commodity production, and by aiding the reproduction of the labour force. It thus tries to

achieve certain necessary objectives: to facilitate continued capital accumulation, by ensuring rational allocation of resources; by assisting the reproduction of the labour force through provision of social services, thus maintaining a delicate balance between labour and capital and preventing social disintegration; and by guaranteeing and legitimating capitalist social and property relations. As Dear and Scott put it: "In summary, planning is an historically-specific and socially-necessary response to the self-disorganizing tendencies of *privatized capitalist* social and property relations as these appear in urban space." In particular, it seeks to guarantee collective provision of necessary infrastructure and certain basic urban services, and to reduce negative externalities whereby certain activities of capital cause losses to other parts of the system.

But, since capitalism also wishes to circumscribe state planning as far as possible, there is an inbuilt contradiction: planning, because of this inherent inadequacy, always solves one problem only by creating another. Thus, say the Marxists, nineteenth-century clearances in Paris created a working-class housing problem; American zoning limited the powers of industrialists to locate at the most profitable locations. And planning can never do more than modify some parameters of the land development process; it cannot change its intrinsic logic, and so cannot remove the contradiction between private accumulation and collective action. Further, the capitalist class is by no means homogenous; different fractions of capital may have divergent, even contradictory interests, and complex alliances may be formed in consequence; thus, latter-day Marxist explanations come close to being pluralist, albeit with a strong structural element. But in the process, "the more that the State intervenes in the urban system, the greater is the likelihood that different social groups and fractions will contest the legitimacy of its decisions. *Urban life as a whole becomes progressively invaded by political controversies and dilemmas.*"

Because traditional non-Marxian planning theory has ignored this essential basis of planning, so Marxian commentators argue, it is by definition vacuous: it seeks to define what planning ideally ought to be, devoid of all context; its function has been to depoliticize planning as an activity, and thus to legitimate it. It seeks to achieve this by representing itself as the force which produces the various facets of real-world planning. But in fact, its various claims – to develop abstract concepts that rationally represent real-world

processes, to legitimate its own activity, to explain material processes as the outcome of ideas, to present planning goals as derived from generally shared values, and to abstract planning activity in terms of metaphors drawn from other fields like engineering – all these are both very large and quite unjustified. The reality, Marxists argue, is precisely the opposite: viewed objectively, planning theory is nothing other than a creation of the social forces that bring planning into existence.

It makes up a disturbing body of coherent criticism: yes, of course, planning cannot simply be an independent self-legitimizing activity, as scientific inquiry may claim to be; yes, of course, it is a phenomenon that – like all phenomena – represents the circumstances of its time. As Scott and Roweis put it:

... there is a definite mismatch between the world of current planning theory, on the one hand, and the real world of practical planning intervention on the other hand. The one is the quintessence of order and reason in relation to the other which is full of disorder and unreason. Conventional theorists then set about resolving this mismatch between theory and reality by introducing the notion that planning theory is in any case not so much an attempt to explain the world as it is but as it ought to be. Planning theory then sets itself the task of rationalizing irrationalities, and seeks to materialize itself in social and historical reality (like Hegel's World Spirit) by bringing to bear upon the world a set of abstract, independent, and transcendent norms.

(Scott and Roweis, 1977)

It was powerful criticism. But it left in turn a glaringly open question, both for the unfortunate planner – whose legitimacy is now totally torn from him, like the epaulette from the shoulder of a disgraced officer – and, equally, for the Marxist critic: what, then, is planning theory about? Has it any normative or prescriptive content whatsoever? The answer, logically, would appear to be no. One of the critics, Philip Cooke, is uncompromising:

The main criticism that tends to have been made, justifiably, of planning is that it has remained stubbornly normative ... in this book it will be argued that [planning theorists] should identify mechanisms which cause changes in the nature of planning to be brought about, rather than assuming such changes to

be either the creative idealizations of individual minds, or mere regularities in observable events.

(Cooke, 1983)

This is at least consistent: planning theory should avoid all prescription; it should stand right outside the planning process, and seek to analyse the subject – including traditional theory – for what it is, the reflection of historical forces. Scott and Roweis, a decade earlier, seem to be saying exactly the same thing: planning theory cannot be normative, it cannot assume “transcendent operational norms”. But then, they stand their logic on its own head, saying that “a viable theory of urban planning should not only tell us what planning is, but also what we can, and must, do as progressive planners”.

This, of course, is sheer rhetoric. But it nicely displays the agony of the dilemma. Either theory is about unravelling the historical logic of capitalism, or it is about prescription for action. Since the planner-theorist – however sophisticated – could never hope to divert the course of capitalist evolution by more than a millimetre or a millisecond, the logic would seem to demand that s/he sticks firmly to the first and abjures the second. In other words, the Marxian logic is strangely quietist; it suggests that the planner retreats from planning altogether into the academic ivory tower.

Some were acutely conscious of the dilemma. John Forester tried to resolve it by basing a whole theory of planning action on the work of Jürgen Habermas. Habermas, perhaps the leading German social theorist of the post-World War Two era, had argued that latter-day capitalism justified its own legitimacy by spinning around itself a complex set of distortions in communication, designed to obscure and prevent any rational understanding of its own workings. Thus, he argued, individuals became powerless to understand how and why they act, and so were excluded from all power to influence their own lives,

as they are harangued, pacified, mislead [sic], and ultimately persuaded that inequality, poverty, and ill-health are either problems for which the victim is responsible or problems so “political” and “complex” that they can have nothing to say about them. Habermas argues that democratic politics or planning requires the consent that grows from processes of collective criticism, not from silence or a party line.

(Forester, 1980)

But, Forester argues, Habermas's own proposals for communicative action provide a way for planners to improve their own practice:

By recognizing planning practice as normatively role-structured communication action which distorts, covers up, or reveals to the public the prospects and possibilities they face, a critical theory of planning aids us practically and ethically as well. This is the contribution of critical theory to planning: pragmatics with vision – to reveal true alternatives, to correct false expectations, to counter cynicism, to foster inquiry, to spread political responsibility, engagement, and action. Critical planning practice, technically skilled and politically sensitive, is an organizing and democratizing practice.

(Forester, 1980)

Fine. The problem is that – stripped of its Germanic philosophical basis, which is necessarily a huge oversimplification of a very dense analysis – the practical prescription all comes out as good old-fashioned democratic common sense, no more and no less than Davidoff's advocacy planning of fifteen years before: cultivate community networks, listen carefully to the people, involve the less-organized groups, educate the citizens in how to join in, supply information and make sure people know how to get it, develop skills in working with groups in conflict situations, emphasize the need to participate, compensate for external pressures. True, if in all this planners can sense that they have penetrated the mask of capitalism, that may help them to help others to act to change their environment and their lives; and, given the clear philosophical impasse of the late 1970s, such a massive metaphysical underpinning may be necessary.

The world outside the tower: practice retreats from theory

Meanwhile, if the theorists were retreating in one direction, the practitioners were certainly reciprocating. Whether baffled or bored by the increasingly scholastic character of the academic debate, they lapsed into an increasingly untheoretical, unreflective, pragmatic, even visceral style of planning. That was not entirely new: planning had come under a cloud before, as during the 1950s, and had soon reappeared

in a clear blue sky. What was new, strange, and seemingly unique about the 1980s was the divorce between the Marxist theoreticians of academe – essentially academic spectators, taking grandstand seats at what they saw as one of capitalism's last games – and the anti-theoretical, anti-strategic, anti-intellectual style of the players on the field down below. The 1950s were never like that; then, the academics were the coaches, down there with the team.

The picture is of course exaggerated. Many academics did still try to teach real-life planning through simulation of real-world problems. The Royal Town Planning Institute enjoined them to become ever more practice-minded. The practitioners had not all shut their eyes and ears to what comes out of the academy; some even returned there for refresher courses. And if all this was true in Britain, it was even more so of America, where the divorce had never been so evident. Yet the picture does describe a clear and unmistakable trend; and it was likely to be more than a cyclical one.

The reason is simple: as professional education of any kind becomes more fully absorbed by the academy, as its teachers become more thoroughly socialized within it, as careers are seen to depend on academic peer judgements, then its norms and values – theoretical, intellectual, detached – will become ever more pervasive; and the gap between teaching and practice will progressively widen. One key illustration: of the huge output of books and papers from the planning schools in the 1980s, there were many – often, those most highly regarded within the academic community – that were simply irrelevant, even completely incomprehensible, to the average practitioner.

Perhaps, it might be argued, that was the practitioner's fault; perhaps too we need fundamental science, with no apparent payoff, if we are later to enjoy its technological applications. The difficulty with that argument was to find convincing evidence that – not merely here, but in the social sciences generally – such payoff eventually comes. Hence the low esteem into which the social sciences had everywhere fallen, not least in Britain and the United States: hence too the diminished level of support for them, which – at any rate in Britain – had directly redounded on the planning schools. The relationship between planning and the academy had gone sour, and that is the major unresolved question that must now be addressed.

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Indigenous placemaking and the built environment: toward transformative urban design

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DISCUSSION ARTICLE



Indigenous placemaking and the built environment: toward transformative urban design

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ABSTRACT

This paper examines how the design and programming of the built environment of settler cities have contributed to the invisibility of Indigenous peoples and minimizing their cultural influence. It seeks to address gaps in the academic literature on Indigenous placemaking and urban design. Indigenous placemaking has the capacity to create positive symbolic capital associated with Indigenous peoples, empowering urban inhabitants in their cultural representation, and advancing the project of truth and reconciliation. To transcend beyond tokenism, Indigenous cultures projected in built form should not be subordinated by settler mainstream decision-making frameworks.

Introduction

Indigenous peoples self-identifying as First Nations, Métis, or Inuit make up roughly five percent of the Canadian population (Statistics Canada 2017). Between 2006 and 2016, the growth of the Indigenous population was nearly 43%, at a rate four times higher than in the non-Indigenous population. About 52% of the Indigenous population lives in Canada's cities, an increase of roughly 60% since 2006. These cities are located on Indigenous traditional territories and homelands. The Indigenous population is comparatively young, with an average age of 32 years, about a decade younger than the non-Indigenous population (Statistics Canada 2017). Indigenous urban inhabitants consider cities 'home', increasingly born to and participating in an urban life (Enviroics Institute 2010). Although many remain connected with non-urban ancestral affiliations, in important ways essential to the overall sense of place, Indigenous peoples are forging belonging and identity in cities where they expect that their cultures and traditions will mean something in urban society (Wilson and Peters 2005). The weave of Canadian urbanism and Indigenous peoples will continue to tighten and take on remarkable patterns over time.

Reconciliation between Indigenous and non-Indigenous peoples is an emergent topic in contemporary academic and public discourse in Canada. To advance the project of reconciliation, the Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada (TRC) has put forth 94 calls to action (TRC 2015). The federal, provincial, and municipal governments are called upon to adopt the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (United Nations

2007) as the guiding framework for reconciliation. The TRC has called upon municipal governments to deconstruct Eurocentric concepts and procedures that have imposed settler-colonial sovereignty over Indigenous peoples and their territories. In early 2019, the Canadian Institute of Planners published its Policy on Planning Practice and Reconciliation to outline how reconciliation might be 'meaningfully embedded in planning practice in Canada and planners build relationships with Indigenous peoples based on mutual respect, trust, and dialogue' (Canadian Institute of Planners 2019, 5). The policy encourages urban planners to enhance their professional practice by increasing their awareness of Indigenous protocols, cultural frameworks, and planning methods.

Negotiations over Indigenous civic identity, cultural visibility, and reconciliation challenge the dominant relations of power and privilege in the shared spaces of settler cities (Wall 2016; Nejad and Walker 2018). Settler colonial authority for the production of space and place has led to the invisibility of Indigenous materiality and memory from urban life in settler nations (Matunga 2013; Walker and Nejad 2017). Eurocentric spatial order was cast across traditional Indigenous territories, and cities became the 'centres' of civilization and culture. The settler state asserted that the territories of Western exploration were void of spatial patterns shaped by the prior occupancy of Indigenous peoples (*terra nullius*). The technologies of map making, survey, and boundary designation were crucial instruments of territorial domination, pushing Indigenous peoples to the periphery (Jacobs 1996; Tuhiwai Smith 1999; Porter 2010). Furthermore, city architecture and urban form became a 'visual buttress' for colonial power and conquest (Matunga 2013, 11). The role of urban design and public space programming in the oppression or the empowerment of Indigenous inhabitants in settler cities is not well understood. This paper argues that accomplishing a more comprehensive Indigenous urbanism – with advanced discussions over design and programming of the built environment – will help to achieve the truth-telling and reconciliation project.

Placemaking and the elimination of Indigenous sense of place

Places of the built environment shape a medium through which culture becomes real in the material world; the built form carries social ideas within its spatial forms (Lefebvre 1991; Massey 1994; Dovey 2010). Place is the meeting point of location, culture, and social relations (Relph 1976) and its design directly affects the health, well-being, and social, economic, and environmental conditions of inhabitants (Carmona 2019). The discussion of how urban 'places' are created is inseparable from Indigenous dispossession and marginalization in cities, as place-creation is inherently a political act and a 'strategic device in the assertion or resistance of power and domination' (Potter 2012, 132). The colonial processes of urban planning and design have re-territorialized urban space in ways that subordinate the Indigenous sense of place, superimposing Western epistemologies of placemaking upon it (Tuck and Yang 2012; Nejad and Walker 2018).

Placemaking, a significant dimension of urban design, should be re-interpreted in the context of design for truth and reconciliation, and socio-spatial justice. Placemaking as a technical, de-politicized, and culturally neutral exercise, as standard urban design pedagogy and practice often suggest, falls short of achieving Indigenous cultural visibility. Placemaking requires a different approach from the 'inclusion' of minority groups in urban design through often ad hoc and small-scale practices (Wall 2016). According to the Indigenous Place Making Council of Canada, placemaking should be a collaborative

process toward reconciliation aimed at creating places that restore Indigenous visibility in Canadian society and project Indigenous identity, worldviews, and values (Hood 2017) (Figure 1). As Sandercock (2003, 10) argues, in the 21st-century 'mongrel city' achieving social and spatial justice for all urban inhabitants requires a different place-sensibility from the bureaucratic regulatory planning that dominated the 20th century:

'a sensibility that is as alert to the emotional economies of the city as it is to the political economies ... a sensibility as curious about the spirit of the place ... and above all a sensibility which can help citizens wrestle new possibilities from space and immerse themselves in their cultures while respecting those of their neighbours, and collectively forging new hybrid cultures and spaces.'

The concept of Indigenous placemaking is different from conventional placemaking as it must be driven by the unmediated participation of Indigenous peoples in urban design processes according to their own knowledge, approaches, and methods (Jojola 2013; Stewart 2015). Indigenous placemaking creates a sense of place for Indigenous peoples living in cities, fulfilling the right to self-determination, land-based claims, and creating a sense of shared Indigenous space for non-Indigenous inhabitants (Thompson-Fawcett, Kitson, and Barry 2018). Reclaiming Indigenous identities in cities remains a big challenge as the perception of urban Indigeneity as 'illegitimate' persists and '[u]rban environments are more representative of Western values, colonial pasts and global identities rather than Indigenous values, which often either exclude or dilute Indigenous identities, weakening connection to place, leading to loss of agency and integrity' (Puketapu-Dentice, Connelly, and Thompson-Fawcett 2017, 3).

Places are centres of individual and collective meanings, identities, and memories (Hayden 1995; Bakshi 2014). The sense of place, *topophilia* (Tuan 1974), or *genius loci* (Norberg-Schulz 1980) is rooted in the lived experience of a particular cultural group, and



Figure 1. Circle of Life Thunderbird House, Winnipeg, Canada.

Source: Authors

the act of placemaking is inspired by that group's values, desires, aspirations, and traditional knowledge. Nevertheless, as Massey (1994) argues, place identities are multiple, complex, and shaped through connections with other places. Their design should not be easily associated with 'nostalgia, inertia, and by implication, regressive policies' (Callard 2011, 301). In Western design and architecture, the ontology of place concerning lived experience has been an abstract context in which material space has been prioritized and the 'sense of place' is secondary and derivative (Dovey 2010). If the concept of place is understood as an abstract framework for defining the materiality of objects that occupy physical space, the way place acts upon human life and contributes to Indigenous marginalization and invisibility in settler cities becomes intricate.

Ontological and epistemological Indigenous construction of place may, to a great extent, be supported by the knowledge that in Porter's view is 'orally constituted, refers to inter-generational sources, and is evidenced not in relation to the empirical inquiry but in reference to custodial responsibilities, narratives, or spiritual awareness' (Porter 2010, 41). The sense of place for Indigenous communities may be created through relationships to the land, and it is not necessarily well understood using the typical processes of Western planning and architecture. In Indigenous perspectives, land, in fact, is itself the 'place'. Indigenous ways of connection to the land often differ from the Eurocentric conceptualizations of land ownership and territorial appropriation. In Māori worldviews, for example, land defines Māori identities and transcends meaning as a physical entity to encompass spiritual connections between people and the earth mother (Puketapu-Dentice, Connelly, and Thompson-Fawcett 2017).

At the time of settlement and across Indigenous territories, newcomers did not try to assimilate, accommodate, or recognize pre-existing Indigenous places on traditional lands. In the absence of cross-cultural understanding, and unequal power relations, Indigenous landscapes were ignored by settlers who justified the imposition of their placemaking cultures by arguing that Indigenous territories were empty, unused, lacking history and 'built' heritage (Porter 2010; Pieris 2012). The colonial processes of urban design have sought to replace Indigenous places with settler colonial landscapes and cityscapes where 'racially coded legacies continue to generate contests over the ownership and belonging of space' (Banivanua Mar and Edmonds 2010, 3). Land ownership and management have been highly contested topics for both settlers and Indigenous peoples because 'the settlers make Indigenous land their new home and source of capital, and also because the disruption of Indigenous relationships to land represents a profound epistemic, ontological, cosmological violence' (Tuck and Yang 2012, 5).

Contemporary urban design and Indigenous communities

Scholars argue that the contemporary postcolonial politics of planning and placemaking are reproducing colonial ideologies and practices that make the presence of Indigenous communities invisible in cities. The gentrification of neighbourhoods, creation of sites of spectacle and consumption, large-scale developments, and decisions on how to celebrate Indigenous heritage are some examples that disrupt the Indigenous sense of place, land claims, and sites of significance (Jacobs 1996; Shaw 2007; McGaw, Pieris, and Potter 2011; Pieris 2012; Potter 2012). For Coulthard (2014), gentrification, urban renewal projects, and the consequent displacement of racialized and Indigenous populations are contemporary forms of colonial dispossession: 'through gentrification, Native

spaces in the city are now being treated as *urbs nullius* – urban space void of Indigenous sovereign presence’ (Coulthard 2014, 176).

The dismantling of Indigenous places happens at every scale, even the smallest and the most local (McGaw, Pieris, and Potter 2011). Disrupting vernacular, bottom-up acts of Indigenous placemaking in contemporary postcolonial urban contexts goes in parallel, paradoxically, with official acts of reconciliation between non-Indigenous and Indigenous communities and Indigenous heritage preservation by settler states. Such official recognition mostly associates Indigenous cultures with non-urban contexts and ‘nature’ (Tuhiwai Smith 1999; Porter 2010). Indigenous peoples are much more likely included in consultations over green space development in planning and design processes than in processes that include shaping the built part of the landscape in cities (Behrendt 2009). The scope of consultation, when it occurs, is controlled under the authority of mostly non-Indigenous ‘experts’, keeping Indigenous engagement at a limited and symbolic level (Porter and Barry 2016).

Recent Canadian Supreme Court decisions outlining a duty to consult and accommodate Indigenous interests may contribute to a shift of power to Indigenous groups, helping to reform planning processes (MacCallum Fraser and Viswanathan 2013). Processes that cities apply most regularly in relation to urban Indigenous peoples focus on temporary events, cultural festivals, and anniversaries, and engagement in planning processes as stakeholder groups like other minority groups such as immigrant newcomers, or civic advocacy organizations (Nejad et al. 2019). Yet, the superficial use of Indigenous cultures in branding and identity creation processes, and commodification of their cultures in urbanism processes, is evident. Commodification which takes distinct Indigenous nations and cultures and recreates them as celebratory expositions to be sold as part of an exotic encounter is dismissive of the cultural density and sophistication of urban Indigenous communities (Andersen 2013).

Indigenous placemaking as a means of transformative urban design

Drawing upon Foucault’s theory of power (1980, 1988) and conceptualizing the built environment as a power/knowledge mechanism – where surveillance and individual control mechanisms are inscribed in the architecture of cities – means that urban space provides opportunities for both oppression and emancipation (Dovey 1999). Physical presence and (re-)claiming public spaces generate what Bourdieu (1986) refers to as cultural and symbolic capital, helping to strengthen urban Indigenous sociality and territoriality. Symbolic capital is related to cultural recognition and the esteem attached to particular tastes, meanings, and values. The design of built form contributes to the production of symbolic capital in cities (Dovey 2010). Western mainstream placemaking cultures have attached negative symbolic capital to Indigenous communities in settler nations, and privileged Eurocentric culture significantly. However, urban design has the potential to generate positive symbolic capital for Indigenous communities, and thereby help to eliminate oppression and advance the project of truth and reconciliation.

Placemaking through naming public spaces, Indigenous public art, and architecture, can help to reclaim symbolic significance of original occupancy and acknowledgment of traditional Indigenous territories (Figure 2). Though, as Malone (2007) argues, to be effective in generating positive symbolic capital, and the empowerment of urban Indigenous communities, the ‘cultural framing’ process must go beyond conventional activities such as art installations. In a settler context, public space commercialization and privatization are major



Figure 2. The Coming Spring, a sculpture in Saskatoon, Canada, to represent the relationships between First Nations, Métis, and settler peoples, and to remember the children who suffered in the residential school system. A joint project of the Saskatoon Tribal Council, City of Saskatoon, Office of the Treaty Commissioner, Central Urban Métis Federation, and Government of Canada.

Source: Authors.

impediments facing transformative urban design. Global economic forces increasingly influence contemporary public spaces; they are being conceptualized as commercial and marketable commodities, sites for stimulating consumption, and not necessarily meeting places of intercultural communication and representation (Carmona 2010a, 2010b). Private control over public space design and management compromises transformative placemaking as well. Such spaces hinder the freedom to protest, free speech, and bottom-up programming (Harvey 2008; Schmidt and Németh 2010). Furthermore, unsettling deep-rooted stereotypes and clichés through design is a serious challenge as the settler imaginations of Indigenous peoples are shaped with colonial narratives (King 2013).

In incorporating urban design activities to reflect Indigenous cultures in cities, it is vital to represent not only the past but also the contemporary presence and contribution of Indigenous peoples to urban society. The focus on the past should consider Indigenous original occupancy and meanings attached to the land. The focus on the present should be about the expression of these meanings in present design and placemaking (Figure 3). The effort should not begin and end with putting Indigenous cultural artefacts in galleries and portraying an anachronistic version of Indigeneity. The historic approach, if it is the only approach given material expression, carries the colonization of the past and present into the future.

Permanency in presence and effectiveness are qualities that could be brought to the built form through placemaking too. In Stewart's (2015, 73) view, Indigenous design is a practice that 'exhibits elements of indigeneity privileging indigenous culture in "resistance" to the Western norms of the status quo ... other attributes of indigeneity include significance as having meaning to someone, materiality as being made of "stuff" to be touched, tasted, plainly seen, having a temperature, a weight, an inherent strength.' The



Figure 3. Algonquin Teaching Circle at Lansdowne Park, Ottawa, Canada. A joint project of the Algonquins of Ontario and City of Ottawa.

Source: Authors.

creation of several well-located, well-designed, well-programmed, and well-maintained permanent Indigenous places is an important principle to guide transformative placemaking (McGaw, Pieris, and Potter 2011). However, when there is a limited understanding of Indigenous cultures and design methods on the part of decision-makers, planners, and designers, initiating creative design work becomes difficult. Innovative Indigenous design elements and approaches can be perceived as exotic or inappropriate in a context which seeks conformity to a conventional design ethos. Consequently, getting approval for a building permit from planning and administrative bodies, coordination with inflexible design codes, and getting consent from residents in adjacent areas creates challenges to making comprehensive Indigenous placemaking operational (Stewart 2015). In an ideal transformative placemaking approach, Indigenous communities decide what should be presented, how it is designed, and where it is placed; it is not limited to design and programming by officials in city planning and administration offices, with Indigenous input.

Research shows that Indigenous participation in urban design, implementing alternative solutions to planning and development, and shared management in cities in Canada, New Zealand, Australia, and the United States is gaining momentum (Smith et al. 2016; Diver 2017; Walker and Nejad 2017). Indigenous placemaking not only re-asserts Indigenous physical, political, and symbolic cultural presence (Figure 4), but as Tomiak (2016, 16) asserts, it helps the city become 'visible as a contested space and space of contestation where competing ontologies and politics challenge settler colonial common sense and state power.'

The ways through which dominant placemaking practices will be made to relinquish control over spatial production and placemaking are convoluted. In highly diverse contemporary cities, places should not be viewed as tightly bound. Indigenous placemaking is about the connection to places, people, and opportunity to participate in spatial production and placemaking beyond tokenism. Making Indigenous places does not suggest isolation and separation. Associations of Indigenous cultures with the land and territory shapes



Figure 4. Monument honouring missing and murdered Indigenous women and girls at The Forks, Winnipeg, Canada. A joint project by Ka Ni Kanichihk Inc. and the Province of Manitoba.

Source: Authors.

a continuous sense of place which has informed an historical and contemporary sense of belonging in the city. Incorporating Indigenous approaches to placemaking, therefore, generates potential for transforming oppressive and privileging social structures. Accomplishing this for contemporary urbanism in settler cities will not be easy and requires an ontological and epistemological transformation in conventional Eurocentric conceptions of placemaking and urban design.

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